



The category of subject in languages with semantic alignment

Silvie Strauß, Leipzig University

SLE 2026, Osnabrück
28.08.2026

Outline

- The category of subject
- Subject and semantic alignment
- Data
- Subject properties considered
- Results
- Conclusion

What is considered a subject?

a. Functionally:

- S and A (Dixon 1979)
- same for all languages

b. Structurally:

- First rank of core arguments (Kibrik 1997)
 - “Most privileged” syntactic argument (Mel’čuk 2014)
 - “Grammatically most prominent argument” (Mithun 2006)
- differs across languages

What is considered a subject?

- Privileged in coding properties: the argument with the coding properties that are found in both transitive and intransitive clauses

(1) Kâte (Nuclear Trans New Guinea; Anderson 1976: 14)

a) *beʔ-Ø* *vale-ve*
pig-ABS come-PST.3SG

‘The pig came’

b) *beʔ-ko* *nana-Ø* *na-veʔ*
pig-ERG taro-ABS eat-PST.3SG

‘The pig ate taro.’

What is considered a subject?

- Privileged in behavioural properties: argument allowing operations that others do not allow (e.g. target of (anti-)passivization, coreferential deletion, special constructions in clause combining)

(2) Kâte (Nuclear Trans New Guinea; Anderson 1976: 14)

a) *vale-la* *beʔ-ko* *nana-Ø* *na-veʔ*
come-PST.SS **pig-ERG** taro-ABS eat-PST.3SG

‘The pig came and ate taro.’

b) **go-ki* (*beʔ-Ø*) *hone-la* (*beʔ-Ø*) *gesaʔke-ve*
2SG-ERG **pig-ABS** see-PST.SS **pig-ABS** run-PST.3SG

‘I saw the pig and it ran.’

What is considered a subject?

(3) Kâte (Nuclear Trans New Guinea; Anderson 1976: 14)

a) *beʔ-Ø* *vale-ve*
pig-ABS come-PST.3SG
‘The pig came’

b) *beʔ-ko* *nana-Ø* *na-veʔ*
pig-ERG taro-ABS eat-PST.3SG
‘The pig ate taro.’

c) —ABS *vale-la* *beʔ-ko* *nana-Ø* *na-veʔ*
 come-PST.SS pig-ERG taro-ABS eat-PST.3SG
‘The pig came and ate taro.’

d) **go-ki* *(beʔ-Ø)* *hone-la* *(beʔ-Ø)* *gesaʔke-ve*
2SG-ERG pig-ABS see-PST.SS pig-ABS run-PST.3SG
‘I saw the pig and it ran.’

→ coding properties: S+P

behavioural properties: S+A

Subject and semantic alignment

- Semantic alignment (also called *split-S* or *active*): distinction between patient-like and agent-like arguments made also in intransitive clauses → no uniform S, but Sa and Sp

(4) Western Basque

a) *ni-Ø* *eror-i* *na-iz*
1SG-ABS fall-PFV 1SG.ABS-AUXI
'I fell.'

c) *ni-k* *borroka-tu* *du-t*
1SG-ERG fight-PFV AUXII-1SG.ERG
'I fought.'

b) *ni-Ø* *harrapa-tu* *na-u-zu*
1SG-ABS catch-PFV 1SG.ABS-AUXII-2SG.ERG
'You caught me.'

d) *ni-k* *harrapa-tu* *zait-u-t*
1SG-ERG catch-PFV 2SG.ABS-AUXII-1SG.ERG
'I caught you.'

Subject and semantic alignment

	agent	patient
intransitive	S	
transitive	A	P

accusative

	agent	patient
intransitive	Sa A	Sp P
transitive		

semantic

	agent	patient
intransitive	S	
transitive	A	P

ergative

A=S≠P	A=S≠P + individual cases of A≠S=P	mostly A=S≠P, some systematic cases of A≠S=P	A=S/S=P	mostly A≠S=P, some systematic cases of A=S≠P	A≠S=P + individual cases of A=S≠P	A≠S=P
accusative			semantic		ergative	

Subject and semantic alignment

- Problem for defining a subject category based on coding properties:
 - no uniform coding of S → no privileged “default” coding that is present in every clause
- Conceivable consequences on behavioural subject properties:
 - no obligatorily filled argument slot
 - either no single privileged syntactic position or some clauses lacking a privileged argument → both core arguments equally privileged?
 - Strong association between semantic role and argument slot
 - would be subverted by operations promoting an argument to another slot → no manipulation of syntactic valency (i.e. passivization or antipassivization)?

Subject and semantic alignment

- What has been observed in semantically aligned languages:
 - generally tend to not have passives (Wichmann 2007)
 - “not organized around the traditional grammatical relations of subject and object” (Velázquez-Castillo 2008: 381 on Guaraní)
 - “no evidence of subject, object or even oblique categories” (Mithun 2006: 213 on Mohawk)
 - “paucity of evidence of any kind which might be used to say that any kind of argument is syntactically privileged over any other kind of argument” (Bowden 2001: 161 on Taba)
 - “Core Status, a syntactic status defining a set of syntactic relations which are equally available to certain salient processes such as raising and relativization” (Durie 1987: 392 on Acehnese)
- Systematic look at 4 most commonly mentioned behavioural subject properties (cf. e.g. Kibrik 1997; Onishi 2001; Haspelmath 2001: 68; Barðdal et al. 2023) in 27 languages with semantic alignment

Data

- 30 languages listed in WALS as having active alignment in either head or dependent marking (WALS 2013: features 98-100A), for 3 of them no information on any of the subject properties found → leaves 27 languages
- Semantic alignment patterns to rather different extents, one language with symmetrical voice (= subject category fully independent of semantic role)
- Data from grammars and syntactic descriptions

Data



Subject properties considered

1. Target of manipulation of syntactic valency

→ closely related to coding properties: changes coding as part of overall clause structure

- Diagnostics:

- Is there a productive way of manipulating syntactic valency? Does it lead to arguments being expressed in another syntactic slot or does it only enable dropping arguments?

(5) German

a) *die* *Katze-n* *jag-en* *den* *Hund*
DEF.PL.NOM cat-PL chase-3PL DEF.M.ACC dog

‘The cats are chasing the dog.’

b) *der* *Hund* *wird* (*von* *den* *Katze-n*) *ge-jag-t*
DEF.M.NOM dog AUX.PASS.3SG by DEF.PL.DAT cat-PL PP-chase-PP

‘The dog is being chased (by the cats).’

Subject properties considered

2. Coreferentiality requirements and coreferential deletion of arguments in complement clauses

- Diagnostics:
 - Are there constructions that require a certain argument of the complement clause to be coreferential with a matrix argument? Can a certain argument be left unexpressed when coreferential with a matrix argument?

(7) Yagua (Peba-Yagua; Payne & Payne 1990: 336, 337)

- | | | | | | |
|----|------------------------|------------------------|----|--------------------------------|------------------------------|
| a) | <i>jiy-vq̣q̣ta-ra</i> | <i>[j̣unúúy-janu]?</i> | b) | <i>jiy-vq̣q̣ta</i> | <i>[sa-j̣unúúy Tomáása]?</i> |
| | 2SG-want-INAN | look-INF | | 2SG-want | 3SG-look Tomáása |
| | ‘Do you want to look?’ | | | ‘Do you want Tomáása to look?’ | |

Subject properties considered

3. Coreferentiality requirements and coreferential deletion in clause combining

- Diagnostics:
 - Which argument of a clause can be deleted when coreferential with which argument of the other clause?
 - Is there another distinction between same-subject and different-subject constructions, and if yes, which argument counts as subject?

(8) Koasati (Muskogean; Rising 1992: 4)

Joekak roomkã itcikhali^hkok Edkã hihcan cokko:lit

Joe-k room-^h itcokhali:ka-k Ed-^h hi:ca-n cokko:lit

Joe-NOM room-ACC enter-SS Ed-ACC see-DS sat_down

‘Joe came into the room, _ saw Ed, and **he [Ed]** sat down.’

Subject properties considered

- 4. property: which arguments can be relativized $\rightarrow$ was not conclusive (almost all languages neutral) and therefore left out in this presentation

Results

1. Manipulation of syntactic valency

- 10 languages no strategies mentioned
- 7 languages strategies to manipulate quantitative valency only (i.e. dropping or impersonalizing arguments without promoting the remaining argument), often not restricted to transitive clauses
- 4 languages reflexives that can also be used to express a passive meaning → lead to P being expressed as Sa
- 6 languages dedicated passives with promotion of P to Sa

→ majority of the languages maintain strict mapping between semantic role and syntactic slot, but not all

Results

2. Coreferentiality in complementation

- Data on many languages missing
- 5-7 languages neutral, not distinguishing between arguments
- 2 languages special construction with coreferential agent-like argument (+ Yuchi optionally)
- 6-8 languages with coreferential S/A
- Warekena with coreferential S/P (?)

→ might in many cases depend on semantics of matrix predicate rather than syntactic restrictions

Results

3. Coreferentiality in clause combining

- Very often not explicitly stated in the grammar
 - 13-20 languages at least one neutral construction
 - 7-10 languages at least one construction with S/A pivot
 - 1 language (Warekena) some constructions with S/P pivot
 - Arapesh same actor in “parallel sentence” construction; switch-reference marking in Koasati said to be “sensitive to active-stative distinction” (Rising 1992: 32), but no details
- might in many cases at a closer look be pragmatic rather than syntactic (cf. Bossong 1984; Mel'čuk 2014: 184)

Results

Presence and salience of a privileged argument position in the different languages (only languages with information on all four properties)

- 2 languages no privileged argument
- 3 languages slightly (= in one domain) privileging the agent-like argument
- 5 languages slightly privileging S/A
- 1 language privileging mostly S/P, less often S/A
- 3 languages privileging S/A in 2-3 domains → all three mostly accusative coding, only small class of Sp verbs

Conclusion

- Split-S patterns in behavioural subject properties very rare
- Most semantically aligned languages not one clearly syntactically privileged argument
- When they do, usually S/A $\rightarrow$ but might in many cases at closer look turn out to be a semantically or pragmatically conditioned preference rather than a syntactic restriction
- Limitations:
 - Syntactic data especially scarce for underdocumented languages
 - In order to be fully conclusive, the results have to be compared to languages with other types of alignment
- Correlation with pervasiveness of semantic coding?



THANK YOU!

References

- Abbott, Clifford. 2000. *Oneida*. München: Lincom.
- Aikhenvald, Alexandra. 1998. “Warekena.” In Derbyshire, Desmond C. & Pullum, Geoffrey K. (eds.), *Handbook of Amazonian Languages*, vol. 4. Berlin: Mouton de Gruyter. 225-439.
- Aldai, Gontzal. 2008. “From ergative case-marking to semantic case-marking: The case of historical Basque.” In Donohue, Mark / Wichmann, Søren (eds.), *The Typology of Semantic Alignment*. Oxford: Oxford University Press. 197-218.
- Anderson, Stephen R. 1976. “On the notion of subject in ergative languages.” In Li, Charles N. (ed.), *Subject and Topic*. New York: Academic Press. 1-23.
- Asatiani, Rusudan. 2013. “The Information Structure and Typological Peculiarities of the Georgian Passive Constructions.” In Bezhanishvili, Guram & Löbner, Sebastian & Marra, Vincenzo & Richter, Frank (eds.), *Logic, Language, and Computation*. Berlin/Heidelberg: Springer. 17-34.
- Barðdal, Jóhanna & Cattafi, Eleonora & Danesi, Serena & Bruno, Laura & Biondo, Leonardo. 2023. “Non-nominative subjects in Latin and Ancient Greek: Applying the subject tests on Early Indo-European languages.” *Indogermanische Forschungen* 128: 321–392.
- Bonvillain, Nancy. 1973. *A grammar of Akwesasne Mohawk*. Ottawa: National Museum of Man.
- Bossong, Georg. 1984. “Ergativity in Basque.” *Linguistics* 22: 341-392.
- Bowden, John. 2001. *Taba: description of a South Halmahera language*. Canberra: Pacific Linguistics.
- Chang, Yan-Yin. 2004. *Subjecthood in Tson grammar*. Doctoral dissertation, National Tsing Hua University Hsinchu.
- Conrad, Robert J. & Wogiga, Kepas. 1991. *An outline of Bukiyip grammar*. Canberra: Australian National University.
- da Silva Facundes, Sidney. 2000. *The language of the Apurinã people of Brazil (Maipure/Arawak)*. Buffalo: SUNY.
- Dixon, R. M. W. 1979. “Ergativity.” *Language* 55(1): 59–138.
- Donohue, Mark. 2008. “Semantic alignment systems: what’s what, and what’s not.” In Donohue, Mark / Wichmann, Søren (eds.): *The Typology of Semantic Alignment*. Oxford: Oxford University Press. 24-75.
- Duff-Tripp, Martha. 1997. *Gramática del idioma yanesha' (amuesha)*. Lima: Inst. Lingüístico de Verano.

References

- Duguine, Maia. 2012. “Basque nominalizations and the role of structural Case in the licensing of null arguments.” In Etxeberria, Urtzi. / Etxepare, Ricardo / Uribe-Etxebarria, Myriam (eds.), *Noun phrases and nominalizations in Basque: syntax and semantics*. Amsterdam: J. Benjamins. 333-374.
- Durie, Mark. 1985. *A grammar of Acehnese: on the basis of a dialect of North Aceh*. Dordrecht: Foris.
- Durie, Mark. 1987. “Grammatical relations in Acehnese.” *Studies in Language* 11(2): 365-399.
- Durie, Mark. 1988. “Preferred argument structure in an active language: Arguments against the category ‘Intransitive subject’.” *Lingua* 74: 1-25.
- Estigarribia, Bruno. 2020. *A Grammar of Paraguayan Guaraní*. London: UCL Press
- Euskaltzaindia. 2021. *Euskararen gramatika* [Grammar of Basque]. Bilbao: Euskaltzaindia.
- Foley, William A. & Van Valin Robert D. 1977. “On the Viability of the Notion of ‘Subject’ in Universal Grammar.” *Berkeley Linguistics Society* 3: 293-320.
- Fähnrich, Heinz. 1986. “Kurze Grammatik der georgischen Sprache.” Leipzig: Verlag Enzyklopädie.
- Frank, Paul. 1985. *A grammar of Ika*. Indiana, university dissertation.
- Frank, Paul. 1990. *Ika syntax*. Dallas, Texas: Summer Institute of Linguistics.
- Franklin, Karl J. 1971. *A grammar of Kewa, New Guinea*. Canberra: The Australian National University.
- Haas, Mary R. 1940. *Tunica*. New York: Augustin.
- Haspelmath, Martin. 2001. “Non-canonical marking of core arguments in European languages.” In Aikhenvald, Alexandra Y. / Dixon, R.M.W. / Onishi, Masayuki (eds.), *Non-canonical marking of subjects and objects*. Amsterdam: John Benjamins. 53-84.
- Hewitt, B. G. 1995. *Georgian: a structural reference grammar*. Amsterdam/Philadelphia: John Benjamins.

References

- Hualde, José Ignacio & Ortiz de Urbina, Jon, 2003. *A grammar of Basque*. Berlin/New York: de Gruyter Mouton.
- Hoijer, Harry. 1933. *Tonkawa: an Indian language of Texas*. New York: Columbia University Press.
- Keenan, Edward L. 1976. “Towards a universal definition of ‘subject’.” In Li, Charles N. (ed.), *Subject and Topic*. New York: Academic Press. 303-334.
- Keenan, Edward & Comrie, Bernard. 1977. “Noun Phrase Accessibility and universal grammar.” *Linguistic Inquiry* 8: 63-99.
- Kibrik, Alexander E. 1997. “Subject-oriented vs. subjectless languages.” In Haspelmath, Martin / König, Ekkehard / Oesterreicher, Wulf / Raible, Wolfgang (eds.), *Language Typology and Language Universals: An International Handbook*, vol. 2. Berlin/New York: Walter de Gruyter. 1413-1423.
- Kimball, Geoffrey D. 1991. *Koasati grammar*. London: University of Nebraska Press.
- Linn, Mary Sarah. 2001. *A grammar of Euchee (Yuchi)*. Ann Arbor: UMI.
- Maring, Joel Marvyl. 1967. *A grammar of Acoma Keresan*. Bloomington, University Dissertation.
- Mel’čuk, Igor. 2014. “Syntactic subject: syntactic relations, once again.” In Daniel’, M. A. & Ljutikova, E. A. & Plungjan, V. A. & Tatevosov, S. G. & Fedorova, O. V. (eds.), *Язык. Константы. Переменные. Памяти Александра Евгеньевича Кибрика*. Saint Petersburg: Aleteija. 169-216.
- Miller, Wick R. 1965. *Acoma grammar and texts*. Berkeley: Univ. of California Press.
- Mithun, Marianne. 2006. “Voice without subjects, objects or obliques. Manipulating argument structure in Agent/Patient systems.” Tsunoda, Tasaku & Nishimitsu, Yoshihiro & Kageyama, Taro (eds.), *Voice and Grammatical Relations*. Amsterdam: John Benjamins. 195-216.
- Mithun, Marianne. 2020. “Typology and nuance: relativization.” *Revista da ABRALIN* 19(3): 104-130.
- Moyse-Faurie, Claire. 1983. *Le Drebu : langue de Lifou (Iles Loyaute); phonologie, morphologie, syntaxe*. Paris : Société d’études linguistiques et anthropologiques de France
- Payne, Doris L. & Payne, Thomas E. 1990. “Yagua.” In Derbyshire, Desmond C. & Pullum, Geoffrey K. (eds.), *Handbook of Amazonian Languages*, vol. 2. Berlin: Mouton de Gruyter. 249-474.

References

- Pet, Willem Jan Agricola. 1987. *Lokono Dian : the Arawak language of Suriname; a sketch of its grammatical structure and lexicon*. Ithaca: Cornell University.
- Pustet, Regina & Rood, David S. 2008. “Argument dereferentialization in Lakota.” In Donohue, Mark & Wichmann, Søren (eds.), *The Typology of Semantic Alignment*. Oxford: Oxford University Press. 334-356.
- Onishi, Masayuki. 2001. “Non-canonically marked subjects and objects: Parameters and properties.” In Aikhenvald, Alexandra & Dixon, R. M. W. & Onishi, Masayuki (eds.), *Non-canonical Marking of Subjects and Objects*. Amsterdam/Philadelphia: John Benjamins. 1-51.
- Rood, David S. 1976. *Wichita grammar*. New York: Garland.
- Rising, David P. 1992. *Switch reference in Koasati discourse*. Dallas, Texas: Summer Institute of Linguistics.
- Seiler, Walter. 1985. *Imonda, a Papuan language*. Canberra: Australian National University.
- Swanton, John R. 2013. “Tlingit.” In Boas, Franz (ed.), *Handbook of American Indian Languages*, vol. 1. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press. 159-204.
- Vajda, Edward J. 2004. *Ket*. München: LINCOM Europa.
- Velázquez-Castillo, Maura. 2008. “Voice and transitivity in Guaraní.” In Donohue, Mark / Wichmann, Søren (eds.): *The Typology of Semantic Alignment*. Oxford: Oxford University Press. 380-395.
- WALS = *World Atlas of Language Structure* (2013). <https://wals.info/>, accessed 25/04/2025.
- Wichmann, Søren. 2007. “Valency-reduction in event-oriented languages.” In Estrada Fernández, Zarina & Wichmann, Søren & Chamoreau, Claudine & Álvarez González, Albert (eds.), *Studies in voice and transitivity (Estudios de voz y transitividad)*. Munich: Lincom Europa. 33-51.
- Wichmann, Søren. 2008. “The study of semantic alignment: retrospect and state of the art.” In Donohue, Mark & Wichmann, Søren (eds.), *The Typology of Semantic Alignment*. Oxford: Oxford University Press. 3-23.
- Zúñiga, Fernando & Kittilä, Seppo (2019). *Grammatical Voice*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Appendix: Data

language	manipulation of syntactic valency	relativization	complementation	clause combining	sources
Acehnese	quantitative valency only	neutral	actor	neutral	Durie 1985, 1987, 1988
Acoma	no	only Sp and P shown	S/A	neutral	Miller 1965, Maring 1967
Amuesha	passive	neutral	S/A	neutral	Duff-Tripp 1997
Apurinã	object-deleting intransitivizer, marginal passive	neutral	neutral	juxtaposition S/A?	da Silva Facundes 2000
Mountain Arapesh	reflexive also used with passive meaning	neutral	neutral?	same actor with “parallel sentences”, otherwise neutral	Conrad & Wogiga 1991
Basque	quantitative valency only	neutral	S/A	neutral?	Hualde & Ortiz de Urbina 2003, Duguine 2012; Euskaltzaindia 2021
Drehu	no	neutral	S/A?	neutral	Moyse-Faurie 1983

language	manipulation of syntactic valency	relativization	complementation	clause combining	sources
Georgian	quantitative valency only (in aorist and perfect)	neutral	?	coordination S/A, otherwise neutral?	Fähnrich 1986, Hewitt 1995, Asatiani 2013
Paraguayan Guaraní	reflexive also used with passive meaning	neutral	?	neutral?	Velázquez-Castillo 2008, Estigarribia 2020
Ika	no	neutral	S/A	S/A?	Frank 1985, 1990
Imonda	no	neutral	?	neutral	Seiler 1985
Ket	no	neutral	?	?	Vajda 2004, Wichmann 2007
Kewa	no	only S and A shown	?	S/A	Franklin 1971
Koasati	passive	only P and oblique shown	?	S/A	Kimball 1991, Rising 1992
Lakhota	quantitative valency only	neutral	?	not applicable	Foley & Van Valin 1977, Pustet & Rood 2008
Lokono	reflexive also used with passive meaning	neutral	?	?	Pet 1987
Mohawk	quantitative valency only	neutral (only incipient)	neutral	neutral	Bonvillain 1973, Mithun 2006, Mithun 2020

language	manipulation of syntactic valency	relativization	complementation	clause combining	sources
Oneida	no	?	neutral	neutral?	Abbott 2000
Taba	quantitative valency only	neutral	neutral	neutral	Bowden 2001
Tlingit	passive	?	?	?	Swanton 2013
Tonkawa	no	?	S/A?	neutral?	Hoijer 1933
Tsou	agent and patient voice	subject	actor	?	Chang 2004
Tunica	no	neutral	?	coordination only S/A shown, otherwise neutral?	Haas 1940
Warekena	reflexive also used with passive meaning (very rare)	S/P	S/P	S/P, S/A or neutral depending on construction	Aikhenvald 1998
Wichita	no	not applicable	neutral?	S/A with motion-cum-purpose, clause chaining neutral	Rood 1976
Yagua	(lexically constrained) passive	neutral	S/A	S/A in infinitival adverbial clauses, otherwise neutral	Payne & Payne 1990
Yuchi	no	Only Sa and Sp shown	(actor)	neutral?	Linn 2001